Shaping Mindsets

Neerja Birla, *52*
Founder & Chairperson, Aditya Birla Education Trust

FOR A VERY LONG TIME, Neerja Birla toyed with the idea of launching an outfit that would cater exclusively to issues related to mental health. However, family matters took precedence over everything else, especially raising her three children—Ananya, Aryaman and Advaitesha. Married to industrialist Kumar Mangalam Birla when she was just 18 (her husband was 22 then), Neerja comes from the prominent Kaslival business family behind the S. Kumars Group. But in 2016, a late-night conversation with her elder daughter Ananya sealed her determination. "She said, 'Just do it' and I said 'OK'." The next morning, Neerja consulted a couple of people and jotted down what she wanted to achieve in the space of mental health. "I had a wish list ready, but there was no roadmap," she says. Perhaps that helped, since she could draw her own rules as she went about addressing one of the most crucial health issues today. Her vision was clear: Change public perception by creating awareness, fostering education, advocating prevention and providing world-class holistic mental health services, regardless of age, gender and socio-economic boundaries.

Mpower, the initiative thus born as part of the Aditya Birla Education Trust, has conducted over 190,000 sessions so far, with 15,453 clients seeking professional help. As many as 61,800 lives have been impacted by Mpower's clinical interventions. It has also conducted over 7,800 workshops in schools, colleges and companies, which have benefited 236,000 people. She says it's heartening to hear stories from those who have been cured, and of those who came back even from the brink of taking their own lives. But the challenges are still huge. "There is a lot of stigma around mental illness, a lack of awareness, facilities and infrastructure, and a treatment gap," says Neerja. What is most crucial is to recognise the symptoms, such as anxiety or a sagging mood, early, and share it with someone.

As the Mpower website displays prominently, 'It's OK not to be OK', and help is just a call away. Part of the treatment plan is to create an environment where the person feels comfortable and safe. "My kids often tell me that mental health is given much more importance at home than physical health," she says. In education, the trust runs two schools for children with special abilities. ■

–M.G. Arun


MANDAR DEODHAR

ACCOMPLISHMENT
Mpower, the mental health initiative launched by her in 2016, has impacted two million lives, covering 33 districts across the country

LEADING ROLE

"Lead from the heart as this is what we women are innately gifted with—empathetic leadership is what sets us apart"

↘ FITNESS BUFF
Workout in any form de-stresses her. She also loves to go cycling and trekking occasionally

↘ BIG-SCREEN PERSON
Doesn't like watching movies online. Enjoys the cinema experience with its popcorn breaks